

Polarization, Political Turnover, and the Stability of Democratic Foreign Policy

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Numerous recent studies find that democratic institutions moderate the impact of domestic political turnover on foreign policy. As such, for many foreign policy outcomes, domestic turnover has little or no impact in democracies. I consider whether this finding holds as political polarization increases. Polarization might lead voters to place less value on compromise with other political actors, freeing leaders to advance policy interests that would be considered riskier in less polarized environments. I test this expectation using the Change in Source of Leader Support database, measures of party and affective polarization, and data on states' voting positions in the United Nations. Across a range of statistical models, I find only weak suggestive evidence that party polarization reduces the constraining impact of democracy. The findings speak to ongoing debates over the role played by democratic institutions in conditioning how and when political competition within countries translates into foreign policy change.

Existen numerosos estudios, llevados a cabo recientemente, que concluyeron que las instituciones democráticas moderan el impacto del cambio político a nivel nacional en relación con la política exterior. En ese sentido, y en lo relativo a muchos de los resultados a nivel de política exterior, los cambios en el liderazgo a nivel nacional tienen poco o ningún impacto en los países democráticos. Sin embargo, en este artículo, nos planteamos si esta conclusión se mantiene a medida que aumenta la polarización política. Postulamos que la polarización podría provocar que los votantes valorasen en menor medida el compromiso con otros actores políticos, lo que permitiría a los líderes promover ciertos intereses políticos que serían considerados más arriesgados en entornos menos polarizados. Ponemos a prueba esta expectativa utilizando, para ello, la base de datos «Cambio en la Fuente de Apoyo al Líder» (CHISOLS, por sus siglas en inglés), así como medidas de polarización partidista y afectiva y datos sobre las posiciones de voto de los Estados en las Naciones Unidas. Utilizamos una amplia variedad de modelos estadísticos y, con ello, solo encontramos evidencias débiles que sugieran que la polarización partidista reduce el impacto limitante de la democracia. Nuestras conclusiones versan sobre los debates en curso con respecto al papel que desempeñan las instituciones democráticas en lo referente a condicionar cómo y cuándo la competencia política dentro de los países se traduce en cambios en la política exterior.

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De nombreuses études récentes constatent que les institutions démocratiques modèrent l'incidence du renouvellement politique national sur la politique étrangère. De ce fait, pour nombre d'issues de politique étrangère, le renouvellement national n'a pas ou peu d'effets dans les démocraties. J'examine si ces conclusions se confirment quand la polarisation politique s'accroît. La polarisation pourrait conduire les électeurs à accorder moins de valeur au compromis avec d'autres acteurs politiques, ce qui donnerait la possibilité aux dirigeants de poursuivre des intérêts politiques qui seraient considérés comme plus risqués dans des environnements moins polarisés. Je teste cette hypothèse à l'aide de la base de données Change in Source of Leader Support (Changement de la source du soutien aux dirigeants), de mesures de la polarisation du parti et de la polarisation affective, et de données sur les positions électorales des États membres de l'ONU. Dans un éventail de modèles statistiques, je ne trouve que de faibles éléments suggérant que la polarisation du parti réduit l'effet restrictif de la démocratie. Les conclusions répondent aux débats actuels quant au rôle joué par les institutions démocratiques quand il s'agit de conditionner quand et comment la concurrence politique au sein des pays se traduit par un changement de politique étrangère.

A growing literature in the past couple decades has considered how turnover in domestic ruling coalitions matters for a host of foreign policy domains. Differences in preferences over political outcomes are a fundamental feature of political interactions that drive political competition (Leeds, Mattes and Vogel 2009). When political turnover in domestic ruling coalitions occurs, foreign policies reflect these differences. Yet a central finding in this literature is that, compared to autocracies, democracies' foreign policies tend to be more stable in the face of domestic political change (Leeds and Mattes 2022). For many foreign policy outcomes, domestic turnover appears to have little or no impact in democracies. Scholars have offered two primary theoretical mechanisms to explain the muted effect of domestic turnover on democratic foreign policy. First, democratic institutions promote policy consistency by incentivizing leaders to win the support of broad segments of society when governing. Second, the need to collaborate with other domestic pillars of power constrains the ability of democratic leaders to deviate drastically from existing policies.

This finding seems potentially less tenable with the increasing perception that political polarization and the staking out of extreme positions by parties is leading to policy instability and upheaval within many democracies in recent times. For example, in the early months of the second Trump administration in the United States (US), US relations with Ukraine, Canada, Russia, NATO, and the European Union shifted rather markedly. While these are the most high-profile, recent examples of dramatic foreign policy changes accompanying new leadership in a democracy, there are reasons to expect that heightened polarization may impact other democratic countries' foreign policies as well. Indeed, since the 1990s, many (though not all) democracies have drifted toward higher levels of polarization (Dalton 2021).¹ This paper seeks to refine this literature by considering whether and how ideological polarization in the positions of major parties and among voters within democracies conditions this relationship.

I consider the possibility that political polarization will undo the constraining impacts of democracy on foreign policy change. Polarization is potentially relevant for the impact of domestic turnover on foreign policy change for a few reasons. Since

¹To be clear, this is not true of all democracies. In fact, polarization has stagnated or declined in some countries, in terms of both party polarization (Dalton 2021) and affective polarization (Boxell, Gentzkow and Shapiro 2022, 2).

some scholars predict that democracy should be stabilizing because of preference homogeneity, as polarization increases and the ideal policy positions of major domestic groups become further apart, domestic turnover in democracies may tend to lead to more foreign policy change. Alternatively, it may be the case that institutions of democracy (so long as the institutions themselves are not eroded by polarization), will continue to moderate how the preferences of competing groups get translated into foreign policy change. To test these expectations, I rely on data from the Change in Source of Leader Support (CHISOLS) project (Mattes, Leeds and Matsumura 2016) and two measures of political polarization. The first is a measure of party polarization from the Party System Polarization Index (PSPI) (Dalton 2017). The PSPI is based on Modules 1–4 of the Comparative Study of Electoral Systems data set (Quinlan et al. 2018). The second is a measure of “affective” polarization in 12 Organization of Economic Cooperation and Development (OECD) countries from Boxell, Gentzkow and Shapiro (2022).

I consider how polarization might condition the impacts of changes in governing coalitions in two domains of foreign policy: (1) voting consistency in the United Nations General Assembly and (2) alliance abrogation. It is in these two areas where Leeds and Mattes (2022) find the most consistent evidence that the impact of political coalition turnover differs between democratic and non-democratic countries.² The results from a series of interaction models indicate that domestic coalition changes are not associated with changes in UN voting patterns in democracies even as the level of polarization within a society increases. Though the data present more challenges in the case of alliance abrogation, the same pattern is evident when I consider the potential for polarization to make new leaders in democracies more likely to renege on their alliance commitments.

While the findings are mostly null, this paper nonetheless speaks to a number of important questions in the foreign policy literature. First, it advances literature on the determinants of foreign policy change and continuity. The findings are consistent with existing evidence that democratic institutions can serve to mitigate the impacts of domestic political turnover on foreign policy, even under conditions of greater polarization. While some evidence shows that extreme polarization can lead to more variability in UN voting on its own (Myrick 2025), this paper directly considers the possibility that more moderate levels of polarization might condition the relationship between domestic change and foreign policy change. Second, it contributes to our ability to predict how increased polarization will matter for relationships between states. At least when it comes to voting behavior in the UN, the findings suggest that polarization may not systematically disrupt continuities in democracies’ foreign policy positions. A crucial caveat here is, of course, that such an interpretation only makes sense if we assume that polarization is not so extreme that it leads to the unraveling of democracy. I discuss this possibility further in the concluding section.

The paper proceeds as follows. In the next section, I briefly review the literature on how domestic turnover might impact foreign policy and how domestic institutions can moderate these relationships. Next, I discuss literature that links polarization to foreign policy and consider how polarization might matter for the relationship between domestic turnover and foreign policy change. I then outline the research design that I use to test my core hypothesis in the domain of voting behavior in the United Nations before presenting the results. The following section outlines the research design for the alliance abrogation models and briefly summarizes the results of that analysis. The concluding section discusses the implications of the findings

²While they also find evidence of such a difference when it comes to the termination of sanctions, they note their findings in this domain are tentative given the limited number of non-democratic sanctions senders in their sample (Leeds and Mattes 2022, 50–1). When they consider the impact of domestic changes on patterns of trade, they find no consistent differences across regime types (Leeds and Mattes 2022, 56).

for future research and, to put the findings in context, elaborates on the possibility discussed above that democracy is endogenous to polarization.

Domestic Turnover and Foreign Policy Change

Political contestation is a product of divergent preferences among groups with access to policymaking power. As such, when new groups assume power, they pursue policies at both the domestic and international levels that reflect their interests and preferences. Scholars have found evidence that political turnover leads to policy changes in a variety of empirical domains, including trade (McGillivray and Smith 2004), investment behavior (Rooney and DiLorenzo 2021), the receipt of development assistance from China (DiLorenzo and Cheng 2019), IMF compliance (Grieco, Gelpi and Warren 2009), the termination of rivalries (Bennett 1997; Rooney 2018), conflict in dyads (DiLorenzo and Rooney 2018), and the expression of foreign policy preferences in the UN (Mattes, Leeds and Carroll 2015; DiLorenzo and Rooney 2021).

However, these domestic changes tend to result in less policy variance in democracies compared to non-democracies (Leeds and Mattes 2022). There are two reasons for this. First, democratic leaders have incentives to win and maintain political support by providing public goods that benefit the electorate at large (Bueno de Mesquita et al. 2003). Because new leaders representing nominally different policy positions will have incentives to gain majority support in the same institutional context as their political opponents, political turnover should lead to less dramatic policy changes in democracies compared to non-democracies. In other words, democratic institutions encourage domestic groups to appeal to broad interests and moderate their positions toward the median voter, leading to greater policy stability across regimes. Second, because of the diffusion of policymaking power across multiple sites within democracies, groups often need to win the support and cooperation of their political opponents when trying to govern (Gaubatz 1996, 116). This means that significant changes to status quo policies should be (relatively) difficult to enact in democracies when opposition groups are unwilling to endorse those changes. These two mechanisms imply that domestic political turnover should be less likely to impact states' foreign policies in democracies compared to non-democracies. The statistical evidence tends to support this expectation (Leeds and Mattes 2022).

Polarization, Regime Type, and the Effect of Domestic Turnover on Foreign Policy

How might political polarization matter for the relationship between domestic turnover, regime type, and foreign policy stability? A number of studies have considered the potential importance of polarization for foreign policy in general, many with a focus on the case of the United States (e.g., Schultz 2017). Jeong and Quirk (2019, 66) find that, at least in the US case, party polarization in the domain of foreign policy has increased over time beginning in the 1960s. Similarly, Smeltz (2022) reports that foreign policy polarization has increased among the US public in the recent past.³ While these studies consider the possibility that polarization in foreign policy exists and is politically relevant, they do not consider how polarization may potentially shape or constrain the impacts of other political phenomena on foreign policy. The one study that is closest to this paper is Myrick (2025), which looks at the relationship between extreme shifts in ideology in terms of "hawkishness" matter for foreign policy consistency in democracies but does not explicitly test whether polarization in general moderates in the impact of domestic changes on foreign policy.

³However, as Hurst and Wroe (2016) note, there remains debate over the nature and extent of polarization in US foreign policy.

As I discussed above, one general type of political change that is salient for foreign policy that may depend on ideological polarization is domestic change in leaders' governing coalitions.⁴ Polarization may matter for the composition of leaders' domestic supporting coalitions in a couple ways. First, polarization might make the preferences of established parties more extreme as leaders of established parties try to cater to extremist groups within their constituencies to prevent them from defecting to more extreme parties. Second, polarization might lead to the ascent of new political parties that represent more extreme ideologies on either end of the political spectrum. Insofar as leaders depend on the support individuals within these parties or on building coalitions of parties to govern, then we should expect that there should be a greater ideological gap between the policies and positions advanced by parties from different coalitions under higher levels of polarization. Further, polarization should, by definition, lead to distinct domestic groups holding policy positions that overlap less and less with those of other groups.

On one hand, there are reasons to expect that polarization will not reduce the constraining impact of democracy. In other words, democracies might still exhibit relative consistency in foreign policy even when polarization within society is high. First, domestic institutions of accountability and the higher number of veto players may constrain more ideologically extreme leaders from making dramatic changes to foreign policy. Just because leaders represent more extreme factions does not mean that they will necessarily be more likely to exclude other segments of society from their winning coalitions when they take power. Second, the greater preference heterogeneity within polarized societies may actually make it *more* difficult to adopt policies that deviate from the status quo (Leeds and Mattes 2022, 66–7). Political opponents to coalitions in power might dig in their heels and refuse to lend their support to a leader's political agenda. Third, issues of foreign policy may be less susceptible to partisan posturing than domestic issues. Thus, even if polarization is increasing overall, it does not necessarily imply that it is increasing (as much) along dimensions associated with foreign policy interests. Fourth, parties in functioning democracies may deliberately exclude extremely polarized parties or segments of the electorate from their winning coalitions to serve a gatekeeping role in the preservation of democracy (Levitsky and Ziblatt 2019, 24–6). This would also imply that, even as parties and the electorate become more polarized, the extent to which polarization impacts policy may be limited.⁵

On the other hand, there are reasons to expect that polarization will undo the constraining impacts of democratic institutions when it comes to foreign policy change. Polarization may lead the electorate to place less value on compromise with other political actors, freeing leaders to pursue policy interests that would be considered more risky in a less polarized environment. As Leeds and Mattes (2022, 67) put it, “a clear danger is that mass ideological polarization undermines the pull toward moderate policies under the median voter theorem.” In other words, although polarization should not affect the institutional context within which different domestic factions operate and constrain one another, it may “affect these actors' *willingness* to do so” (Leeds and Mattes 2022, 67). Leaders may become more willing to pursue more extreme ideological policies with the expectation that they will not be punished by their supporters for doing so. Some anecdotal evidence is consistent with the view that polarization might lead to more erratic foreign policies in democracies. For instance, some attributed South Korea's attempts to reposition its diplomatic posture toward the United States, China, and North Korea following the election of Lee Jae-myung in 2025 to the need to strike a “balancing act” in foreign policy given intense and unprecedented levels of political polarization domestically (Sang-Hun 2025).

⁴While Leeds and Mattes (2022, 66–8) discuss the potential for polarization to factor into the relationship between domestic turnover and foreign policy change, they do not test their conjectures empirically.

⁵I am grateful to an anonymous reviewer for raising this point.

Below I consider the implications of this argument for two different foreign policy domains. Since the core argument is related to variance in foreign policy, rather than developing distinct hypotheses for each outcome, I summarize the overall expectation in Hypothesis 1. Of course, I am careful to outline what this hypothesis implies for each part of the empirical analysis below.

Hypothesis 1: The effect of a domestic coalition change on democratic foreign policy change increases with ideological polarization in society.

Research Design

The first analysis focuses on variance in a country's UN voting position. I build the analysis dataset of state-year observations from the countries that are included in the two polarization data sources described below. Both of these sources already limit their coding efforts to democratic countries, though to ensure that the sample of countries closely matches that used in [Leeds and Mattes \(2022\)](#), I filter the data further prior to estimating the statistical models by restricting the sample of country-years to those with a Polity score of 6 or greater. The analysis in [Leeds and Mattes \(2022\)](#) uses countries of all different regime types and estimates the potential constraining impacts of democracy by interacting a regime type variable with the measure of domestic coalition changes. Thus, to incorporate the additional element of polarization, it would seem that a natural approach would be to estimate a three-way interaction model between polarization, regime type, and domestic turnover. However, since measures of polarization are only available for countries that meet the criteria of being democracies (according to the requirements established by the authors of the respective data collection projects), here I am only able to include democratic countries in the sample (or, below, democratic "initiators"). As such, my baseline expectation is that the estimated coefficient for the domestic coalition change variable should be close to zero and statistically insignificant in the sample. This is because the sample is limited to democratic countries and other research has shown that the impact of these changes in democracies tends to be weak or null.

Dependent Variable

The analysis intends to evaluate whether polarization heightens the impact of domestic political turnover on foreign policy change in democracies. There are many potential domains of foreign policy that could conceivably be affected by domestic turnover. Since I am interested in how polarization might lead groups to express substantially different interests in foreign policy, I use data from [Bailey, Strezhnev and Voeten \(2017\)](#) on states' ideal points in the United Nations General Assembly (UNGA). The authors construct measures of states' ideal points using resolutions that come before the UNGA repeatedly over time so as to allow scholars to study how foreign policy positions differ across countries and over time. I do not expect that states necessarily value consistency in their voting records for its own sake. Instead, looking at changes in the positions that states take in the UNGA is instructive for understanding how the preferences or strategic priorities of states are shifting over time. Using UN voting records has the advantage of taking into account states' expressed interests in a variety of policy domains. Further, strategic voting should be less of a concern in using this measure since the resolutions are not binding ([Bearce and Bondanella 2007](#), 710). And, even if states vote strategically, the way that they vote strategically may be a function of the varying interests that different domestic groups pursue internationally and thus is itself a form of behavior worth explaining ([Leeds and Mattes 2022](#), 31). I calculate the absolute value of the difference in states' ideal points from $t - 1$ to t and take the natural log of that difference for the primary

dependent variable. This is the same measure that [Leeds and Mattes \(2022\)](#) use in their analysis.

Independent Variables

The first key independent variable here is domestic coalition change. I use the Change in Source of Leader Support (CHISOLS) data set from [Mattes, Leeds and Matsumura \(2016\)](#) to measure this variable. This data set seeks to identify “leadership changes within countries [that] bring to power a new leader whose primary support is drawn from different societal groups than those who supported her predecessor” ([Mattes, Leeds and Matsumura 2016](#), 259). I refer to these as “SOLS changes” hereafter. The authors code all such changes for any countries with a population of 500,000 or greater in a given year throughout the period of 1919–2018. I merge in the primary measure of a SOLS change from [Leeds and Mattes \(2022\)](#), which is a dichotomous indicator of whether any such SOLS change occurred during the portion of a year (1) or not (0) prior to the occurrence of UNGA voting.⁶

The conditioning variable of interest is the extent of polarization in a democratic society. I use two measures of polarization to capture two conceptual dimensions of polarization in the literature. The first is the polarization of political parties. To measure party polarization, I begin with the Party System Polarization Index (PSPI) ([Dalton 2017](#)). The index is available throughout the years of 1996 through 2016 for 49 democracies. This data source codes polarization during legislative elections in democracies by using information about the public’s perception of parties’ positions along a left-right continuum and weighting it by the share of votes earned by each party. The resulting measure can vary between 0 and 10, with a score of 0 indicating complete homogeneity in party preferences and a 10 representing a hypothetical scenario where all parties fall at the extremes of the left-right scale. For each country, I begin the time series in the earliest year for which the measure of polarization is non-missing and extend the year variable through 2016. The main measure included in the data is an estimate of the level of party polarization during a particular election. Using only the data points where an estimate is available for a legislative election would result in 146 country-year observations. To increase the number of observations in the study, I employ two methods of imputing values. The first method uses linear interpolation to create a polarization trend from one election cycle to the next. This assumes that the level of polarization in society gradually shifts over time rather than staying relatively static between elections. The second method is carrying forward the most recent value up through the next year where an estimate is available. This method assumes that polarization remains constant between elections. Because the first approach (linear interpolation) seems slightly more plausible—that polarization shifts incrementally over time rather than suddenly assuming a new value when an election is held—I report the results using linear interpolation in the main text and report the results of the models that use the most recent measure of polarization in the [Online Appendix](#).

The second type of polarization I consider is affective polarization. In the context of the United States’ two-party system, [Iyengar et al. \(2019, 130\)](#) describe affective polarization as a situation wherein “[o]rdinary Americans increasingly dislike and distrust those from the other party.” More generally, we can think there being

⁶As [Leeds and Mattes \(2022, 31\)](#) describe it: “Because UNGA voting takes place in the fourth quarter of each year, in most cases it is appropriate to attribute a country’s voting record in a leader transition year to the leader who assumes power that year. New leaders who take office in December are an exception; these executives are unlikely to have much influence on the country’s vote choices that year. For December leader transitions, we thus attribute the country’s UNGA voting in the year of leader transition to the predecessor; December leader transitions and SOLS changes are coded as taking effect only in the following year. Years with multiple leader transitions also present a challenge. Here we identify the leader who was in office in November as the relevant executive and code the presence or absence of a SOLS change based on this leader.”

variation in affective polarization insofar as there is variation in the extent of “animosity” between parties in a political system (Iyengar et al. 2019, 130). To measure affective polarization, I use estimates from 12 OECD countries generated by Boxell, Gentzkow and Shapiro (2022). The authors generate their measures of affective polarization from 149 surveys. This requires harmonizing the various survey instruments to make the estimates roughly comparable across time and space. While this exercise requires a number of assumptions about the comparability of survey instruments and the interpretation of measures in polarization across democracies with differing numbers of major parties, it is, to my knowledge, the only existing data source that strives to provide estimates of affective polarization cross-nationally. It is important to distinguish between polarization in the positions in political parties from affective polarization since, as Leeds and Mattes (2022, 67) argue: “Affective polarization is arguably a particularly significant challenge for foreign policy consistency: to the extent that voters dislike and distrust the other side, they may support and even demand a new leader’s abrogation of foreign policies previously embraced by a predecessor with a different SOLS.” So, despite the limitations of the data, I conduct part of the analysis using this measure of affective polarization. I use the same procedures described above for the measure of party polarization to construct the analysis data set and impute missing values. Figure 1 displays the average levels of polarization in the sample by country, with bands marking the range of variation in the observed measures of polarization in each country throughout the sample. (Cases without a band are those that only have one estimate of polarization during the temporal domain.)

Control Variables

Since my main focus is on estimating the potential conditioning impact of polarization on the relationship between domestic changes and foreign policy change, my statistical models control for potentially confounding factors that would be correlated with polarization, domestic turnover, and foreign policy change. First, within the class of countries considered “democracies,” the level of democracy within a country may be related to the degree of polarization in the society (e.g., Arbatli and Rosenberg 2021), influence the frequency of domestic political turnover, and may affect the stability of foreign policy interests. I control for the level of electoral democracy within a country using data from the V-Dem project (Coppedge et al. 2020). Second, the extent of economic inequality in a society may be related to the degree of political polarization within society (Grechyna 2016) and may lead to greater political instability and thus more leader turnover. Further, insofar as inequality affects the state of the economy, it may lead to changes in foreign policy interests. I use the GINI index as recorded by the World Bank (2013). Third, the absolute level of development of a society may correlate with political turnover and the propensity of states to subordinate their expressed foreign policy interests to more powerful states. I control for a measure of GDP per capita in constant 2015 US dollars (World Bank 2013). Additionally, the extent of globalization in a particular society may matter for polarization and the expression of foreign policy preferences (see Grechyna 2016). I use the KOF Globalization Index (Gygli et al. 2019).

I estimate Ordinary Least Squares regression models with an interaction term between the SOLS change dummy variable and the estimated level of polarization. The estimated standard errors are clustered at the level of the country. Across different models I change the fixed-effects structure to account for time- and country-invariant influences on foreign policy variability. The baseline expectation is that the effect of a SOLS change should be statistically indistinguishable from zero when polarization is low. However, if polarization does lead to a positive relationship between SOLS changes and foreign policy change in democracies, the effect of a SOLS change should increase in size and become statistically significant at higher levels of

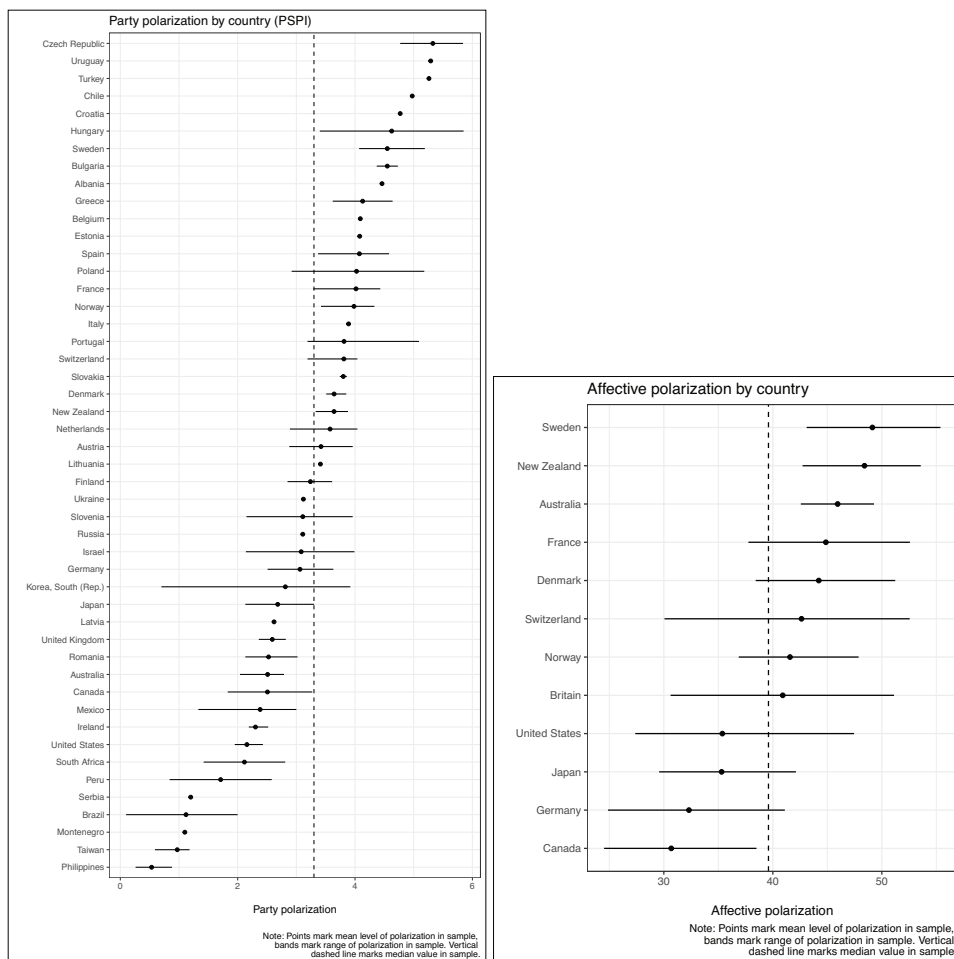


Figure 1. Polarization by country.

political polarization. This implies that the sign of the interaction term in the statistical models should be positive and statistically significant. Descriptive statistics for the key variables are reported in [Table 1](#) and [Table 2](#).

Results

Before testing for a conditioning effect of polarization on SOLS change, I first present a descriptive analysis of the relationship between the two measures of polarization and change in UNGA voting. [Figure 2](#) displays two scatterplots (one for each measure of polarization) with polarization on the horizontal axis and the year-to-year change in UNGA ideal on the vertical axis. Each point represents a country-year observation. From this initial analysis, there appears to be no discernible pattern between polarization and variability of foreign policy interests. Nonetheless, it is still possible that polarization may condition the impacts of SOLS changes on foreign policy change.

[Table 3](#) reports the main regression results. From left to right, the models build on one another to provide increasingly stringent tests of the core hypothesis. Model 1 reports a specification that includes only the key covariates and their interaction

Table 1. Descriptive statistics (party polarization).

Statistic	N	Mean	St. Dev.	Min	Max
SOLS Change	714	0.141	0.349	0	1
Party polarization (linear interpolation)	719	3.319	1.218	0.099	5.850
Polity score	719	9.325	1.104	6	10
GINI index	677	34.729	7.558	23.700	63.400
GDP per capita (log)	698	9.876	0.926	7.184	11.346
KOF globalization index	698	77.370	8.624	52.734	91.070

Table 2. Descriptive statistics (affective polarization).

Statistic	N	Mean	St. Dev.	Min	Max
SOLS Change	503	0.113	0.317	0	1
Affective polarization (linear interpolation)	504	40.016	7.303	24.520	55.380
Polity score	504	9.925	0.360	7	10
GINI index	475	31.873	4.463	22.900	41.500
GDP per capita (log)	486	10.560	0.371	9.327	11.371
KOF globalization index	496	77.028	9.132	45.558	90.811

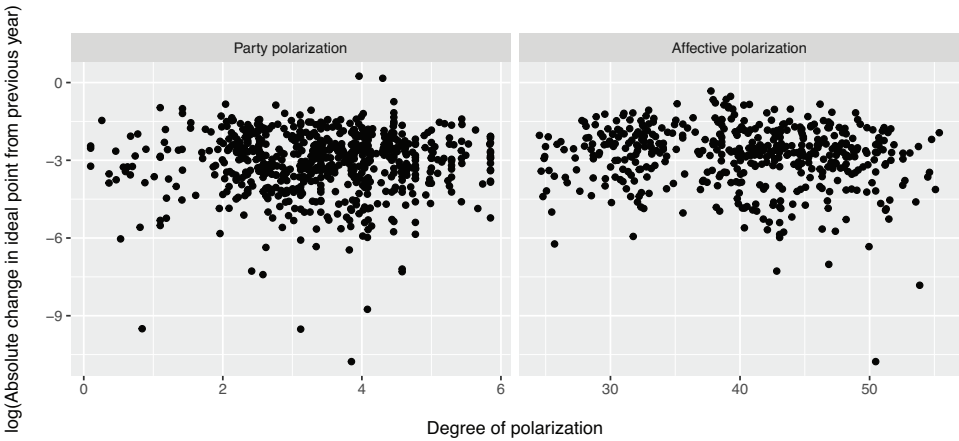


Figure 2. Polarization and change in UNGA ideal point.

without control variables. Model 2 introduces the covariates described in the previous section. Model 3 introduces country-fixed effects to control for any time-invariant determinants of foreign policy stability within countries. Finally, Model 4 adds year-fixed effects to account for any common time shocks that might lead countries to shift foreign policy in particular years.

Across all four models, the baseline coefficient on the SOLS change variable is positive. This indicates that when the polarization measure is at zero, there is a positive correlation between SOLS changes and foreign policy variability. However, as anticipated and consistent with the studies discussed above, the estimate is not statistically distinguishable from zero. In other words, SOLS changes do not seem to matter for foreign policy change in democracies at low levels of party polarization. Hypothesis 1 implies that the coefficient for the interaction term between SOLS changes and polarization should be positive and statistically significant. Consistent with this expectation, the estimate is positive and statistically significant in all four models in table 3. This indicates that, as polarization increases, the estimated coefficient for

Table 3. SOLS changes, polarization, and foreign policy change (linear interpolation).

	Dependent variable: Change in UNGA Ideal Point			
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)
SOLS change	0.006 (0.164)	0.034 (0.166)	0.081 (0.162)	0.029 (0.151)
Party polarization (linear interpolation)	0.002 (0.046)	0.054 (0.051)	0.017 (0.099)	-0.010 (0.114)
SOLS change Polarization	0.061** (0.030)	0.067** (0.030)	0.070** (0.030)	0.074*** (0.029)
Democracy		0.024 (0.034)	-0.055 (0.140)	-0.121 (0.139)
GINI index		0.005 (0.011)	-0.086** (0.037)	-0.076** (0.035)
GDP per capita (logged)		0.308*** (0.082)	1.113 (0.709)	0.385 (0.752)
KOF Globalization index		-0.027** (0.012)	-0.081*** (0.027)	-0.022 (0.036)
Constant	-3.132*** (0.168)	-4.667*** (0.854)		
Country-fixed effects	No	No	Yes	Yes
Year-fixed effects	No	No	No	Yes
Observations	689	668	668	668
R ²	0.004	0.027	0.036	0.017
Adjusted R ²	-0.0001	0.017	-0.044	-0.100
F Statistic	1.456	5.468***	5.890***	2.369**

*p < 0.1; **p < 0.05; ***p < 0.01.

Two-tailed tests. Country-clustered estimated standard errors in parentheses.

OLS estimates.

the SOLS change variable differs meaningfully conditional on polarization. However, this does not necessarily mean that the estimated coefficient will be statistically distinguishable from *zero* for any observed value of polarization in the sample. I explore this possibility below.

It may also be the case that polarization in the positions of political parties is not the most salient aspect of polarization to consider. In [table 4](#), I use an alternative measure of affective polarization. It is this type of polarization that might be particularly prone to undoing democratic consistency in foreign policy as voters pressure their leaders to distance themselves from positions advocated by their predecessors from different political factions. Since the measure of affective polarization is available in the pre- and post-Cold War periods, I also include a dummy variable (*Post-1989*) that takes a value of 1 in years 1990 and beyond and 0 otherwise, since polarization and voting behavior in the UNGA might systematically differ across these periods. As shown in [table 4](#), however, I find no evidence for a conditioning effect of affective polarization on the impact of SOLS changes on democratic foreign policy. Like in [table 3](#), the baseline effect of a SOLS change is consistently positive though not statistically distinguishable from zero. In contrast to [table 3](#), here the interaction term is negative and never attains statistical significance. This finding persists across the various model structures I present in [table 4](#).

So far, the results suggest that party polarization may condition the relationship between SOLS changes and foreign policy variability in a way consistent with Hypothesis 1. The same is not true of affective polarization. As noted above, however, on its own the significant interaction term does not necessarily indicate that our substantive conclusions about the null relationship between SOLS changes and

Table 4. SOLS changes, affective polarization, and foreign policy change (linear interpolation).

	<i>Dependent variable:</i> Change in UNGA Ideal Point			
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)
SOLS change	0.782 (1.339)	1.344 (1.699)	1.347 (1.719)	0.838 (1.530)
Affective polarization (linear interpolation)	−0.017** (0.009)	0.005 (0.011)	0.010 (0.016)	0.022 (0.017)
SOLS change Affective polarization	−0.019 (0.036)	−0.029 (0.045)	−0.029 (0.046)	−0.020 (0.041)
Democracy		−0.201 (0.224)	−0.167 (0.207)	−0.136 (0.148)
GINI index		0.023** (0.012)	0.008 (0.047)	−0.036 (0.041)
GDP per capita (logged)		−0.917*** (0.201)	−1.157 (0.938)	3.539*** (1.298)
KOF Globalization index		−0.005 (0.012)	−0.016 (0.030)	0.043 (0.042)
Post-1989		0.533*** (0.121)	0.724*** (0.107)	
Constant	−2.162*** (0.300)	7.824** (3.304)		
Country-fixed effects	No	No	Yes	Yes
Year-fixed effects	No	No	No	Yes
Observations	475	427	427	427
R ²	0.015	0.077	0.035	0.024
Adjusted R ²	0.009	0.059	−0.007	−0.152
F Statistic	1.909	25.628***	26.360***	2.357**

*p < 0.1; **p < 0.05; ***p < 0.01.
Two-tailed tests. Country-clustered estimated standard errors in parentheses.
OLS estimates.

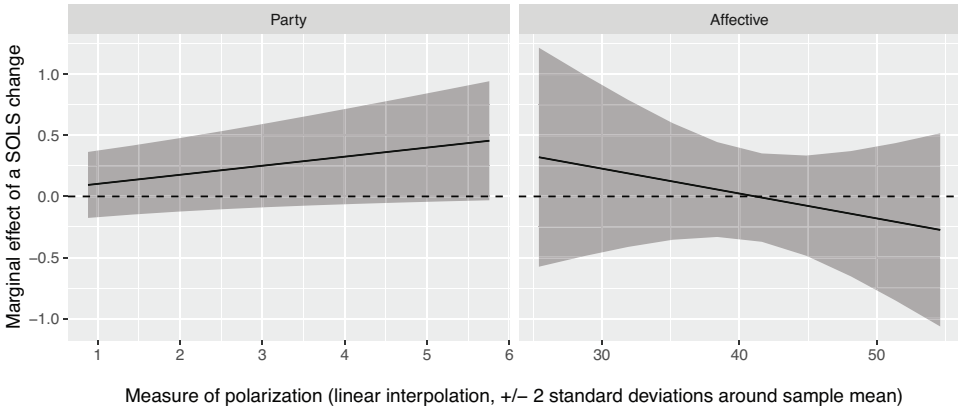


Figure 3. Marginal effect of a SOLS change on foreign policy consistency conditional on political polarization.

foreign policy change in democracies will change. To investigate this possibility, [figure 3](#) displays the estimated coefficient for the SOLS change variable across a range of polarization values. For each of the measures of polarization (party or affective), I calculate the marginal effect of a SOLS change from two standard deviations below to two standard deviations above the sample mean. The left panel of

figure 3 displays the estimates from Model 4 in table 3, while the right panel displays the estimates from Model 4 in table 4.

As hinted might be possible above, the results do not provide very strong support for the expectation that polarization matters for the relationship between SOLS changes and foreign policy positions in democracies. In the case of the left panel, although the estimated effect of a SOLS change modestly increases over the range of the party polarization variable, it is never statistically distinguishable from zero at the 95 percent confidence level. However, it is almost statistically significant at the extreme end of the range, which is loosely consistent with the findings in Myrick (2025). At the same time, the models rely on interpolated measures of polarization, so, if anything, the extent of uncertainty in the analysis is likely underestimated. In the right panel of figure 3 (affective polarization), the estimate starts out positive and becomes negative at higher levels of affective polarization, though it is never close to attaining statistical significance.⁷

There are a few reasons these results might obtain. First, it may be that the constraining impacts of democratic institutions are resilient to the stresses of polarization when it comes to foreign policy. Third, it may be that polarization of the electorate tends to happen along domestic policy fault lines and competing factions within states tend to agree with one another more when it comes to foreign policy positions (at least relative to domestic issues). In other words, if foreign policy polarization tends not to correlate with domestic policy polarization, then there could be significant measurement error in the above analyses. This could also happen if, in presidential systems, the coalitions that presidents build do not align with polarization in legislatures. Still, it seems reasonable to assume that, on average, polarization in foreign policy should tend to correlate with polarization on domestic issues. Indeed, as noted above, existing research suggests that polarization is a phenomenon that, at least in the case of the US, does seep into issues of foreign policy (Jeong and Quirk 2019; Smeltz 2022). This analysis cannot adjudicate between these perspectives, though they are not necessarily inconsistent with one another.

In any case, the analysis above provides only limited evidence that polarization matters for the relationship between SOLS changes and foreign policy stability in democracies. Although the interaction term is statistically significant, the apparent conditioning effect of polarization never actually renders the SOLS change variable statistically distinguishable from zero among the values of polarization observed in the sample. Further, this is only true of the measure of party polarization.

In the Online Appendix, I present the results from a few alternative statistical models. In Section A, I restrict the samples to only the years where a measure of polarization is actually available to evaluate whether the result is an artifact of the imputation method. This dramatically reduces the sample size. There I find no evidence that polarization increases the impact of SOLS changes on voting consistency in the UNGA. In Section B, I use the most recent available data to replace missing values of the polarization measures rather than linearly interpolating between years. This approach also results in a null relationship.

Polarization, Domestic Turnover, and Alliance Reliability

The previous section investigated potential linkages between polarization, SOLS changes, and foreign policy variability as measured in changes in patterns of UN voting behavior. As noted above, UNGA voting is a relatively low stakes, expressive form

⁷Although the interaction term in the models that use affective polarization is not statistically significant, meaning that the effect of a SOLS change does not differ meaningfully across the range of polarization, one interpretation of these findings when taking into account the *direction* of the relationship is that the greater the degree of polarization, the more difficult it is to advance or express foreign policy interests that deviate from the status quo due to political gridlock in democracies. This would be consistent with the view that, rather than leading to more dramatic swings in foreign policy, polarization will simply make policymaking more difficult in democracies.

of foreign policy behavior, albeit one that state leaders likely care about to some degree. Leeds and Mattes (2022) also find that democracies seem to be more reliable alliance partners in the face of domestic turnover compared to non-democratic countries. Does this pattern hold under greater levels of polarization?

Before getting to the analysis, it is important to note that this exercise has limited utility given the weaknesses in the data. In particular, measures of polarization are not available throughout much of the temporal domain that Leeds and Mattes (2022) use to test their hypotheses about the conditioning effects of democracy on the relationship between SOLS changes and alliance abrogation. This problem is compounded by the fact that alliance abrogation is exceedingly rare empirically. In the full analysis data, alliance abrogation occurs in only about 0.45 percent of the observations. In the sample where data on polarization can be imputed and where the “sending” country is a democracy, this drops to about 0.17 percent of the directed-dyad-year observations.

Nonetheless, to investigate the hypothesis above in the context of alliance abrogation, I begin with the replication data from Leeds and Mattes (2022) for the portion of their analysis that examines the relationship between SOLS changes, democracy, and the likelihood that a state abrogates an alliance agreement.⁸ The unit of analysis for this portion of the analysis is the alliance-phase-member-year (Leeds and Mattes 2022, 29). The temporal domain of the original data set is 1920–2018, though the timeframe covered here is necessarily shorter since the earliest year available for the measures of party polarization and affective polarization are 1996 and 1967, respectively. Because of this, it is important to remember that discrepancies in the findings between the analysis here and that in Leeds and Mattes (2022) may result from the different time periods I include in the analysis.

As above, I cannot estimate a three-way interaction model since measures of polarization are unavailable for the non-democratic countries in the sample. As such, I restrict the sample to include only the observations where the alliance member is coded as a democracy in a particular year. Similar to the analysis in the previous section, I interact the measures of polarization with the SOLS change variable to estimate the conditioning impact of polarization on SOLS changes. I expect that the baseline coefficient on the SOLS change variable should be positive but not statistically significant.

The dependent variable in the analysis is a dichotomous measure of alliance abrogation. The variable is “coded 1 if a member violates a key alliance provision and the alliance terminates as a result or if a member voids the alliance before its negotiated expiration date” (Leeds and Mattes 2022, 29). The measure is based on the Alliance Treaty Obligations and Provisions (ATOP) data set (Leeds et al. 2002). I append the data set in Leeds and Mattes (2022) to include the interpolated polarization measures. Though the availability of the polarization data requires me to restrict the sample to democracies, I otherwise hew closely to the model specification adopted in Leeds and Mattes (2022). Because of the issue raised above regarding the infrequency of alliance abrogation in the data, including more than the basic key variables for the analysis leads to convergence problems in a logit model. Instead, I estimate linear probability models.

I report the results of this analysis in table 5. As in the models in the previous section, the baseline coefficient for the SOLS change variable is weakly positive but not statistically distinguishable from zero. This is consistent with the basic argument in Leeds and Mattes (2022)—in democracies, domestic turnover should tend not to produce dramatic shifts in foreign policies, in this case alliance abrogation. Rather than reporting multiple different models for each measure of polarization, I simply include both measures in the same table in separate columns. In the case of the party

⁸This data is available at <https://dataverse.harvard.edu/dataset.xhtml?persistentId=doi:10.7910/DVN/2Z17TK> (Accessed May 30, 2024).

Table 5. SOLS changes, polarization, and alliance abrogation.

	<i>Dependent variable:</i>	
	Alliance violated? Party polarization (1)	Affective polarization (2)
SOLS change	0.001 (0.003)	0.001 (0.021)
Polarization (linear interpolation)	0.001* (0.0004)	
SOLS change Polarization	-0.0003 (0.001)	
Affective polarization (linear interpolation)		-0.0001 (0.0002)
SOLS change Affective polarization		-0.0001 (0.001)
Regime Transition	0.0002 (0.002)	-0.002 (0.040)
delta Military Capabilities	0.0001 (0.001)	-0.0005 (0.012)
Threat Decrease	-0.0001 (0.002)	-0.002 (0.008)
Constant	-0.002 (0.002)	0.004 (0.008)
Observations	2,934	1,348
R ²	0.009	0.004
Adjusted R ²	0.006	-0.003
Residual Std. Error	0.018	0.039
F Statistic	3.040***	0.619

* $p < 0.1$; ** $p < 0.05$; *** $p < 0.01$.

Two-tailed tests. Estimated standard errors in parentheses.

OLS estimates. Cubic time polynomial included but omitted from table.

polarization measure, the baseline estimate indicates that polarization is positively associated with alliance abrogation at the $p < 0.10$ level when a SOLS change has not occurred. This is not the case in the model of affective polarization (Column 2), where the coefficient is negative and not statistically significant. Further, the sign of the interaction term is negative, which is opposite of what we would expect if polarization makes foreign policy more erratic in the wake of domestic turnover. Again, the estimates never attain statistical significance.

Conclusion

Polarization is an increasingly salient aspect of politics in advanced democracies. While polarization may matter for a variety of domestic policy outcomes and processes, the evidence in this paper suggests that at moderate levels it may not undo the constraining impacts of democratic institutions for at least one dimension of foreign policy—voting in the UN General Assembly. It is only at the most extreme values of polarization in the sample where the results uncover a nearly statistically significant impact, which may be consistent with analysis of extreme polarization in Myrick (2025), though for more modest degrees of polarization the analysis suggests the impact of domestic change on foreign policy in democracies remains null. The evidence for alliance abrogation is similar, but given the limitations of the data, those conclusions are far more tentative. This is the case whether I examine a measure of party polarization or affective polarization. While my analysis is based on a

different sample of data than that of Leeds and Mattes (2022) (i.e., only democracies where measures of party or affective polarization are available), I nonetheless recover the basic finding that SOLS changes are either unrelated or weakly related to foreign policy change in democracies. Although the analysis is even more limited when I shift to examining alliance abrogation as the outcome of interest, the basic findings again comport with existing research.

Future research in this line of inquiry might consider the potential for polarization to moderate the SOLS change-foreign policy relationship in other areas of foreign policy. Here, the focus on voting in the UNGA has the advantage of using an aspect of foreign policy that encompasses many different issues and is comparable over time. The analysis also highlights some of the limitations of incorporating measures of polarization into cross-national studies of foreign policy and international politics. In particular, measures of polarization are fairly limited in terms of spatial and temporal coverage, which places bounds on the extent to which scholars of international politics can incorporate these measures into large-N statistical analyses. I have attempted to overcome this problem by imputing data using a minimal and reasonable set of assumptions about how polarization changes in between elections, though clearly it would be preferable to have consistent estimates across time and space. Further, although it is conceivable that polarization would be present and politically salient within non-democratic societies, existing measures are available only for democracies.

An additional caveat is that it may be that polarization matters for the relationship between domestic turnover and foreign policy change by causing the quality of democracy to deteriorate. Indeed, interpreting the results to mean that democracy continues to help constrain countries' foreign policies may be excessively rosy. A more pessimistic take would be that the levels of polarization that we observe in democracies are tame compared to what we might observe in authoritarian settings. The analysis here assumes that polarization can vary within a consistently democratic institutional setting, but it may be that democracy is to some degree endogenous to polarization. Indeed, some evidence suggests that polarization does erode democracy (Arbatli and Rosenberg 2021). If this is the case, then it suggests possible limits to the extent to which we can observe extreme levels of polarization within stable democracies. For now, the results suggest that at least within the subset of countries that remain democratic, normal variations in levels of polarization seem not to matter very much for the constraining impacts of democracy. What the findings cannot say, however, is anything broader about the relationship between polarization and foreign policy stability. Indeed, we only observe measures of polarization in democratic contexts where voters' revealed preferences are assumed to have some meaningful correspondence to policy outcomes.

Supplementary material

Supplementary material is available at the *Foreign Policy Analysis* data archive.

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